# Time is a Closet

Art and Story by Mei Fujimatsu

IT WAS ALWAYS KEPT LOCKED.

EVEN I, HER OWN GRAND-DAUGHTER, WAS NEVER ALLOWED TO ENTER WITHOUT PERMISSION.

GRAND-MOTHER'S DRESSING ROOM, WHICH HAD REMAINED SHUT EVER SINCE HER PASSING, WAS OPEN.

GRANDMOTHER'S PRECIOUS DRESSING ROOM...

OH DEAR, THERE ARE PEOPLE INSIDE GRANDMOTHER'S DRESSING ROOM. SHOULD I CALL THE GUARDS...?

BUT MORE IMPORTANTLY... WHO ARE THESE TWO DELICATE, MYSTERIOUS GIRLS...?

THEY LOOK ALMOST LIKE YOUNG MAIDENS, AND YET... THERE IS SOMETHING ABOUT THEM THAT FEELS UNMISTAKABLY MATURE...

UM... EXCUSE ME?

HELLO!

HELLO.

HELLO...?

AND IT SHOULD HAVE BEEN LOCKED.

HOW DID YOU GET IN HERE?

THIS IS MY GRAND-MOTHER'S TREASURED DRESSING ROOM.

SO YOU'RE LADY YUKIKO'S GRAND-DAUGHTER.

I WASN'T INFORMED THAT WE WERE EXPECTING ANY VISITORS TODAY.

CLACK

THAT WAS DEFINITELY THE KEY TO THIS ROOM...

WE'RE FRIENDS OF LADY YUKIKO'S.

SHE GAVE US THE KEY AS WELL.

WHAT LOVELY CLOTHING.

THEY DIDN'T LOOK LIKE THEY WERE LYING...

RIGHT?

MY APOLOGIES.

WE SHOULD HAVE INFORMED YOU BEFORE COMING. THAT WAS RUDE OF US.

WE UNDERSTAND VERY WELL HOW PRECIOUS THIS DRESSING ROOM WAS TO LADY YUKIKO.

SHE WAS SOMEONE WHO DEARLY LOVED HER COSTUMES, AFTER ALL.

BUT WE SIMPLY WISHED...

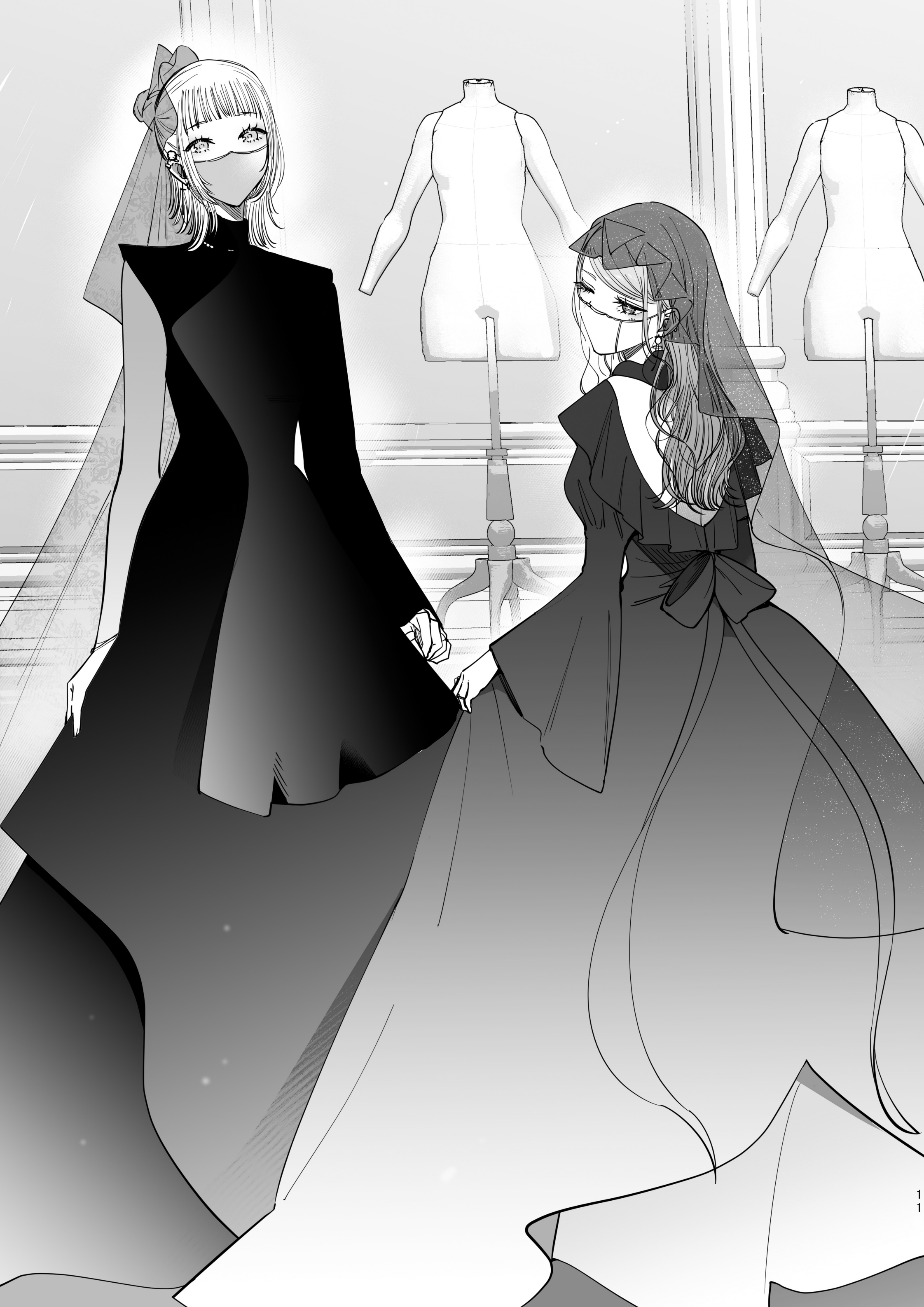
TO WEAR THESE GARMENTS ONE MORE TIME.

WE'RE RATHER FOND OF ADORNING OURSELVES IN ALL SORTS OF ATTIRE.

WE'LL MAKE SURE TO LOCK THE ROOM PROPERLY BEFORE WE LEAVE.

OF COURSE.

WOULD YOU... PERHAPS ALLOW ME TO SEE YOU WEARING THEM?



HOW BEAUTIFUL...

WOULD YOU...

ALSO LET ME SEE BENEATH THE MASKS?

AH...

BEAUTIFUL...

BEAUTIFUL...

IT FELT AS THOUGH I WERE WATCHING A PLAY UNFOLD BEFORE ME.

JUST LIKE THE STAGE STORIES GRANDMOTHER USED TO TELL ME WHEN I WAS LITTLE...

MHM! SO FUN!

LADY YUKIKO MADE THESE COSTUMES FOR US.

THIS IS SO FUN.

TAP

SHE WAS A STAGE ACTRESS OF SUCH BEAUTY AND BRILLIANCE.

THAT ANYONE WHO MET HER EVEN ONCE WOULD FALL UTTERLY UNDER HER SPELL.

SHE FOUND SUCCESS AS AN ACTRESS WHILE STILL YOUNG,

AND GAINED EVERYTHING OTHER SCOULD ONLY ENVY.

MORE THAN ANYONE ELSE,

STATUS, FAME, WEALTH...

AND YET...

SHE WAS HAUNTED BY THE FEAR OF DEATH.

HER PARENTS, WHOM SHE LOST TO ILLNESS...

AND THEN THE DEATH OF THE DEAREST FRIEND TO WHOM SHE HAD BEEN DEEPLY BOUND...

SHE HAD DREAMS ALMOST EVERY NIGHT.

DREAMS IN WHICH HER PARENTS AND HER FRIEND WOULD COME TO VISIT HER,

WHILE SHE HERSELF LAY IN A COFFIN.

IT WAS AS THOUGH THEY WERE GENTLY INVITING HER TOWARD DEATH.

BUT ONE NIGHT, SHE HAD A VERY STRANGE DREAM.

IN IT, TWO UNFAMILIAR WOMEN DRESSED IN BLACK SLEPT INSIDE A COFFIN, AS THOUGH THEY HAD DIED IN HER PLACE.

THE MOMENT LADY YUKIKO AWOKE, SHE IMMEDIATELY COMMISSIONED A DESIGNER TO MAKE THE GARMENTS.

CREATED THE COSTUMES, SHE SAID.

SOMETHING GRACEFUL LIKE AN ANGEL, YET BEWITCHING LIKE A GRIM REAPER...

RATHER... A COSTUME FIT FOR A BRIDES.

THEY WERE NOT MEANT FOR HERSELF.

THEY WERE MEANT FOR THE TWO WOMEN SHE HAD SEEN IN HER DREAM.

SHE MADE A WEDDING DRESS FOR THE DEAD.

WHEN WE FIRST MET LADY YUKIKO, SHE SAID THIS TO US:

FOR MY SAKE, THE ONE YOU LONGED TO MEET, I WANT YOU TO TRY DYING.

FOR MY SAKE, THE ONE YOU LONGED TO MEET, I WANT YOU TO TRY DYING.

AND SO... WE DIED FOR HER.

INSIDE THE COFFIN...

IT WAS SO COLD...

DRESSED IN THESE GARMENTS...

BUT LADY YUKIKO KEPT SMILING AT US SO WARMLY THE WHOLE TIME.

SHE STROKED OUR HEADS WITH SUCH GENTLE, WARM HANDS.

YOU TWO ARE...?

I REMEMBER HEARING ABOUT IT ONCE AS WELL.

THE STORY OF THE STAGE OF DEATH... BUT THAT WAS A VERY LONG TIME AGO.

AND SO... IT WAS HAPPILY EVER AFTER.

YES.

AFTER THAT, IT SEEMS LADY YUKIKO NEVER HAD THOSE DREAMS AGAIN.

WE DIED ONCE BEFORE HER.

TO SLIP OUR ARMS INTO THESE GARMENTS, WHOSE BEAUTY SWEETLY BECKONS ONE TOWARD DEATH.

AND EVEN AFTER DEATH, WE FOUND OURSELVES LONGING ONCE MORE.

WE'RE GHOSTS.

SO PERHAPS...

WE'LL ENJOY THESE CLOTHES JUST A LITTLE LONGER BEFORE WE LEAVE.

WE'LL RETURN EVERYTHING NEATLY, SO PLEASE DON'T WORRY.

GHOSTS...?

U-UM... ALL RIGHT...

MHM...

BECAUSE COSTUMES MADE JUST FOR US ARE SPECIAL.

POP

I FEEL AS THOUGH I'VE FELT THIS WAY BEFORE...

AND YET... WHY IS MY HEART POUNDING SO HARD?

DID I JUST ENCOUNTER A PHANTOM...?

JUST LIKE THE DREAMS GRANDMOTHER ONCE HAD...?

OH, YOU POOR THING.

I HAD A SCARY DREAM. A DREAM WHERE PAPA AND MAMA DISAPPEARED...

I'M SORRY, GRANDMA...

MIYAKO, CAN'T YOU SLEEP?

JUST FOR TONIGHT, LET'S SLEEP TOGETHER IN MY ROOM.

THAT WAS THE ONE AND ONLY NIGHT MY USUALLY STRICT GRANDMOTHER GENTLY STROKED MY HEAD.

THE NIGHT SHE TOLD ME THE STORY OF THE STAGE OF DEATH.

AND LET ME SLEEP IN HER ROOM.

THAT WAS THE DAY I MET THEM.

THE TWO WOMEN...

...FROM THE PAINTING.

JUST AS THEY HAD APPEARED THERE...

STEP

GRANDMOTHER... AFTER THAT PERFORMANCE, WERE YOU NO LONGER AFRAID OF DEATH?"

AT THAT MOMENT, DEATH SOUNDED BEAUTIFUL YET TERRIFYING...

DID YOU FACE YOUR END...?

WITH WHAT FEELINGS...

I WANT TO SEE IT TOO.

SOMEDAY...

THAT WAS FUN.

WHAT ERA SHALL WE VISIT NEXT?

[TIME TRAVELERS?] THE TWO WOMEN LEFT BEHIND IN PAINTINGS AND PHOTOGRAPHS

TWO GIRLS LOVED BY REAL ARTISTS ACROSS TIME

I WONDER WHAT WE SHOULD WEAR NEXT.